

Readings

A Time for Everything Ecclesiastes 3:1-8

There is a time for everything,
and a season for every activity under the heavens:
a time to kill and a time to heal,
a time to tear down and a time to build,
a time to weep and a time to laugh,
a time to mourn and a time to dance,
a time to scatter stones and a time to gather them,
a time to embrace and a time to refrain from embracing,
a time to search and a time to give up,
a time to keep and a time to throw away,
a time to tear and a time to mend,
a time to be silent and a time to speak,
a time to love and a time to hate,
a time for war and a time for peace.

The Little Blue Engine

by Shel Silverstein (1930-1999)

The little blue engine looked up at the hill.
His light was weak, his whistle was shrill.
He was tired and small, and the hill was tall,
And his face blushed red as he softly said,
"I think I can, I think I can, I think I can."
So he started up with a chug and a strain,
And he puffed and pulled with might and main.
And slowly he climbed, a foot at a time,
And his engine coughed as he whispered soft,
"I think I can, I think I can, I think I can."

With a squeak and a creak and a toot and a sigh,

With an extra hope and an extra try,
He would not stop — now he neared the top —
And strong and proud he cried out loud,
“I think I can, I think I can, I think I can!”

He was almost there, when — CRASH! SMASH! BASH!
He slid down and mashed into engine hash
On the rocks below... which goes to show
If the track is tough and the hill is rough,
THINKING you can just ain't enough!

Quitting

Who taught you how to quit?

Who helped you understand how to know when to quit and when to stick it out? Who modeled different ways to end a job, leave a relationship, give up on a dream? Who gave you instructions on the importance of releasing yourself from an obligation in a dignified manner without burning any bridges? Who gave you lessons on how to pack it up, ...break it off, ... cut it out, ... shut it down, ...give it the elbow,... kiss it good-bye,... and give it the old heave-ho? Did anyone teach you?

Conversely, who taught you how to keep going and hang on?

Everybody! We live in a culture that deeply values perseverance. Think of all the stories we've heard about how important it is to continue on, even when we want to quit. Our heroes are the underdogs who keep fighting against all odds. Our role models are the people who never give up. Our legends "don't know the word quit." Weren't we all raised on the story of Thomas Edison, the great inventor - who is said to have made 1,000 unsuccessful attempts to create the lightbulb. Where would we be if he hadn't seen it through till the end?

Recent research provides data on the importance of perseverance. Studies lay out the fact that the one thing needed for success is grit. Not talent, education, good looks, or who you know. The biggest predictor of success is the tenacity to deal with a setback, pick yourself up, dust yourself off, and start all over again,... and again, and again and over again. Our society worships dogged determination.

Think about all of the interviews you've ever heard that equate achievement with not giving up. The reporter asks "How did you do it? How did you win, or succeed, or stay alive? To what do you attribute your victory, or celebrity, or survival?" The answers are almost always the same - only the details change.

"Well Tom, I just didn't give up!"

"You know Michelle, I kept working hard, giving it everything I've got."

"Gosh Diane, I kept believing that I could do it." And, "Lester, I owe it all to God."

That's it folks. Those few basic rules will help you reach any goal, overcome any challenge, outperform anyone else. - No matter how hard it gets or how long it takes, don't quit. Always give it your very best. No matter how discouraged or disappointed you become, keep believing - in yourself, your dream, and the surety of your ascendancy. And finally, make sure to thank God, or the people in your life who made it all possible.

These things may indeed be true. And it's just not that simple. If we look at the Olympics, for example, the chances that an individual will just make it to the games is roughly 1 in 500,000. Of the 11,656 athletes who made it to the games in 2020, less than 3% won gold. That's a whole lot of people not giving up, always doing their best, keeping the faith, and showing their gratitude - people who didn't quit and who didn't win.

We are obsessed with this whole notion of hanging in there, to the point of it being comical. In trying to research quitting I discovered that there's not much out there. The one caveat is that there are a fair number of books, articles, and videos about "How To Know When It's Time To Quit Your Job." When I did find material about quitting, it focused on persevering. "If you're reading this, you must be thinking about quitting. Don't! Here's a pep talk to help you keep going." The whole idea of quitting is anathema.

In our world, quitting is a very bad thing. Let's start by acknowledging that it is not ok to quit. The thesaurus lists a number of synonyms for the word "Quitter." They are not nice. A person who quits is defined as "Someone who gives up easily. A person who lacks courage. One who shirks from duty or responsibility." Drop-out, Loser, Coward, Sissy, Lay-About, Deserter, Gutless, Malingerer

Perseverance is associated with moral character and trustworthiness. The maxims guiding our lives insist that what matters most is grit and "stick-to-it-ness." "Quitters never win. Winners never quit." "If at first you don't succeed, try harder." "Successful people keep moving. They make mistakes, but they don't quit." And, "Failing is not the worst thing in the world; quitting is."

Wow! No wonder we don't want to think about it!

Recently I learned that a dear friend is filing for bankruptcy. You could have knocked me over with a feather. This woman is one of the most responsible, self-disciplined, conscientious people I know. For the sake of today's sermon, let's call her "L."

Several years ago, "L" started her own business. She'd been meticulous in her preparations, setting herself up for success before leaving her steady job and leaping into entrepreneurship. Once "L" was up and rolling, it didn't take long for her business to thrive.

Then covid hit. No matter how hard she worked or how creative she was at finding new ways to do business, she could not stay afloat. She kept trying. In fact, it was her perseverance and sense of responsibility that brought her to the edge of no return.

We talked about how painful and awful all of this was for her, about the constant anxiety, sleepless nights, emphatic attempts, and exhausting effort she experienced while trying desperately to save her business, to no avail. My good friend, like most of us, finally quit because she had no other choice.

I listened as she talked about the process of reconciling her reality with her dream. She shared how humiliating it was to have creditors and debt collectors calling her. She explained the emotional and practical work involved in filing for bankruptcy. Not easy stuff.

What surprised me most was my own attitude toward "L" after hearing her story. Our long history of friendship and the affection and admiration between us didn't factor into my visceral reaction to her story of failure. Learning about "L" quitting had a big impact on me.... I respected her more.

The expectation that "L" would succeed in her business was a no-brainer. Of course she would do well, and of course I'd be proud of her for leaving her secure work to pursue her dream. I did not expect "L" to quit. Quitting was way harder for her than persevering. There was nothing in my competent friend that prepared her for calling it a day. She took the harder path.

"L" has become my "Quitting Role Model." I watch her and learn: "Oh, this is how to handle yourself when you have nothing left." "OK, this is a healthy way to keep your self-esteem and dignity when all around you would tear you down." "Look, there is life after such a death. She has some honest happiness and service going on after quitting." It is fascinating that I respect her more.

Quitting has been much maligned in our culture. Yet when talking to my hospice patients about regrets, most often they will say they wish they had quit earlier - a job, a marriage, living to fulfill others' expectations. Quitting takes courage and strength. It is not easy to go against the dictates of our society. It requires a certain moral fortitude to seriously challenge what we think it means about ourselves if we quit. Perhaps we should hear more pep talks telling us that we have what it takes to pack it in.

Our disdain toward quitting makes it difficult to have honest conversations around it. For most of us, the shame and guilt associated with packing it in precludes any possibility of having an open discussion about it. There are few resources if you want to know how to navigate such foreign territory. Maybe that's why Paul Simon's song "50 Ways To Leave Your Lover" is such a classic.

You Just slip out the back, Jack / Make a new plan, Stan / You don't need to be coy, Roy / Just get yourself free.

Here's the thing, despite all the hype about sticking it out and staying on, quitting can be a very good thing. "Quitting has great value. Generally, quitting redistributes things, including jobs and affections. Quitting creates spaces and opportunities for others."

(Viewpoints; Quitting: In Defense of a Maligned Act - By Evan Harris)
A surprising number of people can benefit when we let go. The fact is, we are all quitters. We have all failed; We just don't talk about it.

There is a false belief that it is easy to quit. But it's not really. Research and experience demonstrate that in many ways, it is easier to keep going.

There is a particular irony that we have all been "raised on a steady diet of lessons on grit and perseverance, but the truth is that the culture is really preaching to the choir. Yes, there are lazy people, slackers, and folks who don't step up, but generally, human beings are hardwired to hang in, not to leave or quit. All those adages—like "Winners never quit, and quitters never win"—aren't really necessary. What's hard for human beings is letting go. We are... a conservative and loss-adverse bunch.

"How we think provides the super-glue that keeps us stuck. We can thank our ancient forebears because there wasn't an evolutionary advantage to have the Paleolithic hunter crawl into his cave if he didn't bag the caribou or to give up if he failed to ford a raging river the first time. Many of our habits of mind derive from a time in human history when the challenges of life were largely physical and perseverance tended to pay off. Even though that was then and this is now, our brains simply haven't caught up." (8 Ways You Can Tell That It's the Right Time to Quit - Peg Streep 2015)

There are several places where our minds get stuck. The *sunk cost fallacy* is the irrational thought that we should continue with someone or something because of all the time, energy and money we have invested in it. If we give up, we believe we are completely wasting everything we've already done. We don't think of staying as an obstacle to something better.

Nothing can make up for the time and energy we have spent. Yet we may be able to prevent using up more resources going forward. When you are thinking about ending something and are stuck on how much you've already invested in this endeavor, ask yourself, " If I

knew back then, when I started, what I know now, would I have started at all?"

Our tendency to look for positive cues and being overly optimistic get in the way of knowing when to leave. Combining these with intermittent rewards instill the idea that if we just try harder and don't give up, anything is possible. One of the biggest obstacles to quitting is hope. Just the tiniest bit of success can keep us going. *"The one day the boss says something that, for once, doesn't cut you off at the knees, or the time your beloved actually does something you've been begging them to do, suddenly you're no longer heading for the door but settling in for a spell and totally sure that everything will work out."* (Peg Streep 2015)

Most of us are aware that what we can't have becomes even more desirous. Not only do we chase what we can't have, we double down on our efforts. If we are told that something is impossible, this impractical pride sets in. We will expend an absurd amount of energy proving that we can indeed do what others said we could not. Sadly, after we've exhausted ourselves, we are dissatisfied and wonder if it was really worth it after all.

We are afraid of making mistakes. Not quitting is a form of risk avoidance. We stay with the devil we do know rather than chance the one we don't. We don't want the upheaval of change, or we don't know what else to do. Or our identity becomes intertwined with some aspect of our lives. I think of the patients I've known who continue unsuccessful courses of treatment because "Who would I be if I'm not the woman fighting cancer?"

It's also interesting to notice that we are far more likely to be criticized for ending something "too early" than for hanging on too late. People are more understanding of the poor souls who hang on till the bitter end than they are of the selfish or cowardly folks who jump ship.

Given the shame and guilt associated with quitting, it's easy to understand why people stay too long. Quitting is akin to failure and it is an easy slide from "I failed" to "I am a failure." We fear that we will

forever have a negative mark by our name. There is no room for grace.

We are so abhorrent of quitting that many of us don't quit until we have no other choice. We quit because we can't go on. The body or mind collapses, we get fired, laid off, or the business closes - or eventually, we die. We have equated quitting with such moral failure that even when we are miserable, our health is suffering, and our spirits are deflated, we persist, thinking that even if we destroy ourselves in our perseverance, "At least we didn't quit!"

It turns out that people who are able to quit earlier and more often generally have enhanced self-confidence and greater skills managing transitions than folks who avoid leaving at all costs. Research has shown that people who recognize the dangers or futility of a situation and quit easier have a broader sense of self. They do not define themselves by one activity and its rewards, such as a career. It's less stressful to end something if you already know you have other, good, options. These people focus more on the goals than avoiding mistakes.

The truth is that while our society has been extolling the virtues of sticking it out and steadfastness, we've been praising ourselves for doing what comes most naturally. And we've been denigrating the very thing that requires more of us.

Quitting takes effort. It is not a passive event. Quitting is work. And it is an art.

Before we are able to stop whatever it is that we've been doing, we need to imagine that on some level, life can be different. We need to admit that we have options. We aren't as stuck as we thought.

Once the idea that we could leave a situation has gotten our attention, the careful process of discernment can begin. Why do we want to give up? Should we just push through, hold on, and get past this difficult time, trusting that things will be better? What information is my body telling me? Is staying harmful to my well-being, or will it build character? What do we think will happen when we quit? Will the upheaval that follows our leaving be worth it? Do we have goals and

direction for the future? Do we have a plan - and do we have a "Plan B?" Is this really the time to quit?

How do we want to end things? These are the times I wish I'd had a "Quitting Role Model." Someone to teach me what questions to ask, how to listen for answers, and when a line of questioning is a waste of time and energy. Granted, even if we had a "Quitting Check List," no one can tell us what to do. Ultimately, figuring out what is best for us always lies with us. Still, I wish I'd had more examples of what it looks like to "Quit Well."

Think back to those interviews with winners. Wouldn't it be great if we could hear a reporter ask.. "So, how does it feel to give up on your dream? ... When was that moment when you realized it was hopeless?... How did you figure out that you just don't have it?... Are you pleased with the way things ended?" I'd love to hear an interview like that!

Sometimes, this horrible thing we fear is the best thing that can happen to us. Quitting is usually harder than perseverance, because of the way we are made and the way we've been conditioned to think. It is not passive or inherently destructive. Quitting easily and early may be a sign of a well-put together individual - the opposite of a loser. Quitting is a skill and an art, and something we generally are figuring out on our own. Perhaps someday that will change. Just as we are beginning to see articles about how to know if it's time to quit our jobs, it is possible that we will realize that most people could use some coaching on everything from resigning a job to leaving a relationship to forgoing further treatment for cancer.

Finally, quitting is an act of faith. It is taking seriously the belief that things can be different, can be better. This is not as good as it can get. Walking away and calling it a day is an action. It is a leap of faith, or sometimes more of a limp into faith. Giving up on the now, letting go of the dream, ending the relationship, stepping away from the obligation, and resigning from the job all demonstrate trust in a higher quality of life.

In acting on our own behalf, we exhibit trust in who we are and our ability to maneuver into a happier, healthier existence. We are also acting on the notion that God or a beneficence universe, or at least chance, is on our side. Quitting is not just hanging in there and hoping. It is doing something. It is making a change. Whether we are strategic about it, with a carefully thought out resignation letter and requests for recommendations, or if we seem to be impulsive, throwing our hands up in the air and declaring "I can't take this any more!" - we are casting our vote in favor of improvement. This is a different certainty than doggedly continuing on. It is a radical move. You may define it as faith in yourself, in life, in God, in the beneficence of the universe. Quitting is not passive and it certainly exemplifies hope.

The next time you are tempted to quit - pause - and sit for a moment with the possibility that hanging it up may be the best course of action. Before you begin giving yourself the perseverance pep-talk, think seriously about the various possibilities. Don't automatically assume that you should stay the course. Maybe it is time to quit. Stay for a little while in this holy moment. Don't brush it away with your discomfort. Ask yourself how the Holy is showing up and with you.

Quitting is not wrong, cowardly, or small. It is not necessarily the easy way out. It may instead be the harder calling. Just because our society has labeled it negatively doesn't mean it is the wrong way to go. Quitting may be exactly what is most needed.

Let us increase our vision and our own self-confidence.

Let us courageously let go of what no longer serves us.

Let us have the wisdom to quit early without self-recrimination and the adventurousness to quit often.

And finally, let us rejoice in the faith underneath it all, reminding us of possibilities previously unseen.

Amen and Amen

